

2003 Honda Element EX

AWD / Real Time 4WD · 5-speed manual · 128,137 miles

VIN 5J6YH275X3L.....

Sanitized portfolio example · Phoenix, Arizona · Prepared September 20, 2026

SAMPLE DATA — NOT A REAL VEHICLE LISTING. This document demonstrates the customer report format only.

CURRENT RECOMMENDATION

CONDITIONAL NEGOTIATE — PPI REQUIRED

The rare AWD/manual configuration is appealing, but Massachusetts rust exposure and unexplained internal transmission work control the decision. Do not pay a deposit or buy before a buyer-selected lift inspection.

ASKING PRICE

\$6,500

MILEAGE

128,137 miles

REPORT LEVEL

Full-history buyer report

HISTORY EVIDENCE

CARFAX

OPENING OFFER

\$4,800–\$5,000

REASONABLE RANGE

\$5,000–\$5,500

ABSOLUTE CEILING

\$5,750

Your next three moves

1. Request the complete transmission-repair invoice before scheduling a viewing.
2. Book a buyer-selected lift inspection focused on structural rust and the right-front repair area.
3. Use the inspection result to hold the price ceiling at \$5,750—or walk away.

Executive evidence screen

Reasons to continue

- Desirable EX, AWD, and 5-speed manual configuration
- No branded title, total loss, or odometer rollback reported by CARFAX
- Substantial recent tires, brakes, fluids, axle, ignition, and belt service
- The \$6,500 ask is not absurd if the structure and drivetrain are genuinely sound

Reasons to slow down

- Approximately 21 years of Massachusetts road-salt exposure
- Seller acknowledges rust
- Accidents reported in 2005 and 2010
- March 2026 internal transmission repair is not itemized
- Long service-documentation gap before 2024

Evidence still required

- No buyer-selected pre-purchase inspection has been completed.

Vehicle identity & evidence

Item	Evidence	Finding
VIN	VERIFIED	Complete VIN validated and matched to the reviewed source material; partially redacted in this public sample
Configuration	VERIFIED	2003 Honda Element EX, K24A4 2.4L, 5-speed manual, 4WD/AWD
Mileage	REPORTED	128,137 listing miles; latest CARFAX reading 126,555 on July 31, 2026
Asking price	REPORTED	\$6,500 private-party ask
Title brands	HISTORY	No salvage, junk, rebuilt, fire, flood, hail, lemon, or odometer brand reported by CARFAX
Exterior color	HISTORY	Records changed from brown to gray; inspect for repaint and prior repair

Evidence standard: Listing observations, seller claims, history-report entries, public research, and inspection findings are labeled separately. Missing evidence is never treated as favorable.

Listing and history reconciliation

The seller describes roughly 30,000 miles of personal use, while the history timeline implies approximately 39,447 miles since the 2024 purchase. That arithmetic discrepancy is not proof of deception, but it should be clarified. The listing's 192-horsepower claim conflicts with the factory rating of approximately 160 horsepower. Recent work is encouraging, but consequential transmission and axle repairs require itemized invoices.

History source

CARFAX supplied, dated September 20, 2026.

- Three personal owners reported
- No branded title, total loss, or odometer rollback reported
- Two accidents reported: 2005 and 2010
- Twenty-six service records reported
- No open recall reported by CARFAX as of the report date

Date	Mileage	Event	Why it matters
2003–2024	21–88,690	Approximately 21 years registered in Massachusetts	Extended road-salt exposure makes structural corrosion the controlling risk.
2005-03-30	about 9,000	Accident with another motor vehicle	Repair severity is not described; inspect prior body work.
2010-10-31	about 43,000	Right-front impact; vehicle drivable; airbags did not deploy	Inspect right-front structure, axle area, alignment, and paint work.
2026-03-06	123,198	Clutch hydraulics serviced and internal transmission repaired	Invoice is required because the replaced internal components are not identified.
2026-07-31	126,555	Axle, knock sensor, brakes, plugs, fluids, and oil service	Positive recent work, but invoices and post-repair scan are still needed.

Model-specific and regional risks

Rear-frame and trailing-arm corrosion

Transport Canada recalled salt-area Elements because corrosion can allow a rear trailing arm to separate. The U.S. did not issue the same broad campaign, so a clean U.S. recall result does not establish structural safety.

- Inspect both rear trailing-arm front mounts and surrounding unibody on a lift
- Inspect rear subframe, suspension pick-up points, rockers, seams, brake lines, and fuel lines
- Look behind cladding and reject fresh coating that conceals the structure

PASS GATE: Perforation, separating metal, heavy scale, swelling seams, cracks, patches, soft mounts, or concealed corrosion.

Clutch and internal transmission repair

The March 2026 entry names clutch master/slave cylinders and an internal transmission repair but does not identify synchros, bearings, gears, clutch disc, pressure plate, release bearing, or flywheel work.

- Obtain the complete March 2026 invoice
- Cold-test every upshift and downshift
- Check for grind, pop-out, clutch slip, shudder, chatter, bearing noise, and case leaks

PASS GATE: Missing invoice plus any shift fault, pop-out, clutch slip, or abnormal transmission noise.

Prior right-front impact

CARFAX reports a 2010 right-front impact and the 2026 history includes front-axle repair.

- Measure paint depth and inspect welds, seams, and panel gaps
- Check alignment, wheel bearing, axle, control arm, tie rod, and tire wear
- Confirm straight tracking and braking

Age and Arizona-use readiness

A 23-year-old vehicle needs baseline engine, cooling, electrical, emissions, and A/C verification regardless of reputation.

- True cold start and full scan including pending/permanent codes and readiness monitors
- Cooling-system pressure test and fan operation
- Strong A/C after heat soak; battery and alternator load test
- Verify valve-clearance, coolant, and knock-sensor repair evidence

Recalls, campaigns & public-history checks

Recall / campaign	Known status	Required action
U.S. Honda campaigns / airbags	CARFAX reports no open recalls; right airbag assembly replaced in 2019	Obtain a current VIN-specific Honda dealer campaign printout before purchase.
Transport Canada rear-frame corrosion campaign	Foreign-market inspection clue, not a U.S. VIN recall	Use it to target the lift inspection; do not represent it as an open U.S. recall.

Public-history search

No indexed exact-VIN auction, salvage, theft, or prior-sale page was found during the review. That means not found—not proven absent. Match the dashboard, door label, title, and CARFAX VINs and consider NMVTIS or AutoCheck as a second title source.

Price analysis

Current asking prices for 2003 Elements vary sharply with mileage, seller type, configuration, geography, and condition. The examples below bracket the subject rather than value it directly. The proposed range discounts dealer markup, 211,842 miles, a private-party sale, incomplete drivetrain documentation, prior right-front damage, and unresolved corrosion exposure. Manual/AWD rarity earns a premium only after the structure and drivetrain pass inspection.

Dated asking-price context

Date	Source	Market example	Mileage	Ask	How it informs this report
Sep. 26, 2026	Edmunds dealer listing	2003 Element EX AWD, 5-speed manual	69,808	\$7,495	Far lower mileage and dealer retail; supports an upper bracket, not a direct comparison.
Sep. 26, 2026	Car and Driver marketplace	2003 Element EX; drivetrain not established	128,000	\$9,600	Lower mileage; transmission, AWD status, condition, and seller type were not established.
Sep. 26, 2026	CarGurus dealer listing	2003 Element EX AWD, 5-speed manual	286,426	\$6,594	Matching rare configuration but substantially higher mileage; dealer asking price.
Sep. 26, 2026	Portland Craigslist private listing	2003 Element EX AWD, automatic	216,482	\$4,550	Closest mileage and seller type, but automatic and in a different market.

Market examples are asking prices observed on the stated date—not verified sale prices or appraisals. Configuration, mileage, seller type, geography, and condition limit direct comparison.

Condition-adjusted buyer range

Evidence outcome	Buyer range	Action
Structural rust, unsafe mounts, or patched mounting area	PASS	Do not buy at a normal price.
Moderate nonstructural rust or incomplete drivetrain invoices	\$4,250–\$4,750	Only consider after a specialist inspection.
Sound structure, minor surface rust, clean scan and test drive	\$5,000–\$5,500	Reasonable private-party target.
Exceptional PPI, complete records, cold A/C, emissions ready	\$5,750 maximum	Hard ceiling; do not chase rarity above it.

Pricing rule: Dealer asking prices are not private-party transaction values. Deduct documented repair, maintenance, title, accident, corrosion, tire, A/C, emissions, and missing-record risk.

Buyer-selected inspection checklist

Structure and underside

- ☐ Rear trailing-arm mounts
- ☐ Rear subframe and suspension pick-up points
- ☐ Rockers, seams, floor, brake and fuel lines
- ☐ Evidence of patches or fresh concealing undercoat

Engine and cooling

- ☐ True cold start
- ☐ Full OBD scan and readiness
- ☐ No chain rattle, knock, smoke, or overheating
- ☐ Cooling pressure test and fan operation
- ☐ Oil level, condition, and leaks

Clutch and transmission

- ☐ No slip, shudder, chatter, or hydraulic leak
- ☐ No shift grind or resistance
- ☐ No gear pop-out
- ☐ No case leaks
- ☐ Correct Honda manual-transmission fluid

AWD, chassis, and Arizona checks

- ☐ No rear-differential chatter on tight turns
- ☐ Four matching tires with similar tread
- ☐ Inspect right-front impact/axle area
- ☐ Strong A/C at idle after heat soak
- ☐ Current Arizona emissions pass

Seller verification

- 1 Can you send clear photos or video of both rear trailing-arm front mounts and the surrounding underside?
- 2 Can you provide the complete March 2026 invoice showing what was repaired inside the transmission and which clutch components were replaced?
- 3 Can you provide the July 2026 axle and knock-sensor invoice?
- 4 Is the title clean, in your name, and free of liens?
- 5 May I perform a true cold start, full diagnostic scan, and buyer-selected lift inspection?
- 6 Do you have a current emissions result and VIN-specific Honda recall printout?

Suggested message

Hi Carson—I'm interested in the Element. Before setting up an inspection, could you send clear photos of both rear trailing-arm front mounting areas and the surrounding underside? Because it spent most of its life in Massachusetts, that is the main safety item I need verified. Please also send the March 2026 invoice showing exactly what was repaired inside the transmission and whether the clutch disc, pressure plate, and flywheel were replaced. If those look good, I'd like to arrange a cold-start test drive and independent pre-purchase inspection. I won't ask you to hold it without inspection.

Decision gate

Proceed

Clean title, consistent VIN/history, sound structure, documented drivetrain work, clean scan, and acceptable road test.

- ☐ Negotiate within the evidence-based range
- ☐ Complete purchase only after the buyer-selected inspection

Pass

Unsafe corrosion, unexplained drivetrain faults, inconsistent title/VIN story, emissions failure, or inspection refusal.

- ☐ Do not rationalize structural or transmission risk because the configuration is rare

REPORT VERDICT

CONDITIONAL NEGOTIATE — PPI REQUIRED

Negotiate only after a clean lift inspection, complete transmission invoice, cold test drive, full scan, current emissions readiness, and title verification. Pass if the seller resists any of those steps.

Sources & limitations

- Archived listing reviewed for this sanitized portfolio example
- CARFAX supplied by buyer, generated September 20, 2026
- Edmunds 2003 Honda Element EX listing, observed September 26, 2026
- Car and Driver 2003 Honda Element EX marketplace results, observed September 26, 2026
- CarGurus 2003 Honda Element EX AWD results, observed September 26, 2026
- Portland Craigslist 2003 Honda Element EX AWD private listing, observed September 26, 2026
- NHTSA VIN decoder
- NHTSA model-year recalls
- NHTSA VIN recall lookup
- Transport Canada rear-frame corrosion recall 2021024
- Honda 2003 maintenance schedule

This report is research and decision support, not a mechanical inspection, appraisal, title guarantee, warranty, or prediction of future reliability. CARFAX may not contain every accident, service, or title event. A buyer-selected pre-purchase inspection remains mandatory.